

Whose Vibe is it Anyway? Negotiating Definitions of Cozy Games

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Abstract

While many games that are now widely considered ‘cozy’ games, such as Animal Crossing and Stardew Valley have been on the market for close to a decade (or more), cozy games as a genre have gained in popularity over the last several years. This can be seen not only in the number of titles that have increasingly been given the label of ‘cozy game’ by game designers and marketing teams, but also in how players describe them. But what exactly are cozy games? How are they defined, by who, in what context(s), and for what purposes? From design elements to vibes, this paper will explore a range of definitions found through the perspectives of design literature, games and mainstream media, and players on TikTok. It demonstrates that what makes a game ‘cozy’ is widely variable, socially constructed, and often personal, despite the best design intentions.

Keywords: Cozy Games, Game Design, Player Studies, TikTok, Fan Culture.

1. Introduction & Background

As video games continue to permeate our entertainment landscape and leisure time, the range of experiences offered to players continues to expand. From role playing games, combat, survival, horror, and adventure genres to multiplayer, cooperative, competitive and co-located gameplay, video games offer players moments of engagement and escape. A relatively recent addition to both genre categories and experience is being defined and labeled as ‘cozy’ games. Traditionally, as is the case with generic definitions, the aesthetics, mechanics, and gameplay experiences often existed before the genre label (Kirkland, 2011) and it is often in retrospect that the generic specificities become more clearly defined. We can see this in earlier games such as *The Sims* (Electronic Arts; Maxis, 2000) and *Animal Crossing*

(Nintendo, 2001) franchises. The design principles of these two franchises always embodied low-stakes, relaxing gameplay but at the times of their initial releases fell into the simulation (life and social) categories.

As video games and their genres evolved and expanded through development and definition over time, the consideration of how a game makes the player ‘feel’ has edged its way into generic definitions. No longer is a video game simply defined by its mechanics (first person shooters) or settings (space) and narrative structures (fantasy) but is now also defined by how the game(s) make the player feel when playing the game. This can be seen in genres such as horror (feeling scared, anxious, etc.), narrative-driven games (from empathy to sadness), and now cozy games, where the feeling is literally the core genre descriptor and a primary design intent. As Short et al. (2018) state “cozy is an adjective” that can guide the design of any game. This is both a blessing and a curse when it comes to attempting to consolidate the design, academic, and media definitions with that of players and fans of the genre.

Like many genres across media, the definitional elements, boundaries of inclusion and exclusion, and intended/expected experiences vary depending on who is creating the definition and to what end (Arsenault, 2009). From production teams needing a common vocabulary during development, marketing and media using classification terms to set consumers’ expectations, to the consumers definitions based on previous experiences and expectations (Clarke, Lee, and Clark, 2017), the commonalities and differences between stakeholders and players often make it challenging to create an agreed-upon definition, let alone cohesive, collective experience.

When it comes to ‘cozy’ games, the challenge is no different. How they are defined, by who, in what context(s), and for what purposes will always inevitably yield different variations. Yet, with the ever-growing social media landscape, players are an

increasingly important voice in not only how they experience games, but how they are defined as well. What impact this has on the development of cozy games is yet to be seen, but player feedback and critique has played a role in design decisions in other contexts (Perks, 2020; Game Informer, 2011).

Player definitions can be as diverse as the players themselves. Cozy games are often defined by their fans along multiple axes that are sometimes seen as synergistic and sometimes in conflict with each other to some extent. Fan discussions of these games often focus on aesthetics, calling out a cute or simple art style and focus on characters that range from cartoon oriented, sometimes anime-inspired or chibi characters with production processes that use pixel art, flat art styles, or other mechanisms to achieve a lighter, less gritty tone than more photorealistic games (Waszkiewicz and Bakun, 2020). Yet fans also describe the mechanics of these games in the same lens, noting a focus on gameplay that does not involve heavy or difficult combat, and can instead focus on a lighter, more casual mood, often incorporating subjects or themes that are less weighty or dark, which coincides with many of the design principles we will see throughout this paper.

Fans also note the settings of the worlds in which these actions and characters are placed, noting a focus on either exploration or activities such as farming, a slower-paced interaction with the world, and a recognition of its beauty. How this beauty is conceptualized is of course changing, as there are an increasing number of cozy games that focus on darker worlds and themes, coming to be known as ‘dark cozy games’ (Carpenter, 2023), from the underworld of Greek mythology to other dungeons, pits, and labyrinths. But these worlds are generally depicted in the same cute and cuddly way that defines the character styles, with a focus on beauty and tranquility (Waszkiewicz, 2024). And thus, not every cozy game is *Animal Crossing* (Nintendo, 2000), as the genre leaves room for something like *Spiritfarer* which contained many complex and less-than-comforting themes (Wagner *et al*, 2021), described by its developers as “a cosy management game about dying.” (Thunder Lotus Games, 2020). The point here is that there is not one axis alone that defines a cozy game in the eyes of many fans, that there are often multiple considerations and experiences, and that these are not always agreed upon as to what constitutes a unified definition of cozy games.

From design elements to vibes, this paper will explore the range of definitions through the perspectives of design literature, games and mainstream media, and players on TikTok to demonstrate that what makes a game ‘cozy’ is widely

variable, socially constructed, and often personal, despite the best design intentions. Our aim is to demonstrate how cozy games are formally defined by game designers and developers, academic research, how game and mainstream press mediate these definitions, and finally how fans, in their own words through their TikTok videos, define the genre and their own gameplay experiences. By doing so, the goal is to demonstrate that what players consider to be cozy often follows a similar yet deviating description from more formal definitions of cozy games and what it means to experience them. Moreso when a game’s design is grounded in a feeling, which is fundamentally grounded in the player even if an attempt to elicit the ‘vibe’ of coziness is made through its game design, there will rarely be consensus.

2. Methods

Any useful definition of cozy games requires investigating how players themselves have come to understand the term, as well as how they themselves debate the term and its parameters. Much as Consalvo and Paul found in relation to “real games,” discussions around what counts or not as “cozy” is a continuing matter of debate and speculation within the cozy games’ player community, if not in other areas (2019). While this paper cannot undertake a comprehensive history of the term itself, it does endeavor to explore how prominent contemporary players, game developers, and the games and mainstream media use and debate the term. This paper empirically tracks how cozy games have been defined by game developers, game press, and game players. Importantly, each author worked independently on different aspects of this research, as we did not want to use preconceived notions of what the genre was, but rather to each explore various facets of its definition and compare/contrast these with each other. Genre definitions are, we hypothesized, socially constructed in each of these various spaces, and rather than begin with a definition and then exclude various sources that didn’t meet certain criteria, we instead attempted to cast a wide net and examine multiple conflicting views on the coziness of games.

To do so, the paper engages with several sets of literature and data: (1) academic and game developers’ working definitions of what constitutes a cozy game; (2) games and mainstream press discussions of cozy games in outlets including *Polygon*, *Games Radar*, *PC Gamer*, *Washington Post*, and *Rolling Stone*; and (3) in the discourse generated by popular cozy games content creators on TikTok.

Included game and mainstream media websites were based on the search terms ‘cozy game’, ‘what are

cozy games’, and ‘why play cozy games’. Of the results, sixteen articles were selected based on the range of publication dates from 2019-2024 which coincides with the rise in popularity of cozy games specifically through and beyond the Covid-19 pandemic. The aim was not to develop a comprehensive list of media definitions, but rather to collect a range of perspectives in definitions and reasons people play cozy games that would bridge the design literature and those of the content creators’ TikToks.

Based on game design literature and review of the sixteen game and mainstream media articles, we created a chart of design elements and principles that were most addressed in the academic, design, and media literature as shown in Figure 1. This chart, and the following analysis, is thus inductive in its approach – while we identify several key characteristics of coziness, these are drawn directly from observations of these communities and their media outputs (news stories, videos, discussion boards, interviews or statements by developers, etc.), rather than being pre-identified beforehand.

This chart helped inform the review of content creators on TikTok. Sources were not tracked in the chart, as its creation is intended to serve as an overview of common trends. Deviations from the formal definitions made by content creators have not, at this time, been mapped into the chart, but have been addressed throughout the paper where possible.

2.1. Content Creators on TikTok

TikTok was chosen as a space to study due to multiple factors, including its current general level of popularity as a social media site, its demographic alignment with the predominant audience for cozy games (both spaces draw large numbers of Millennials and GenZ women, among others (Game Mode Gets Cozy, 2023; Howarth, 2024)), the diversity it provides in terms of racial, ethnic, and sexual representation for content creators, and its format, which favors succinct, catchy videos that encourage creators to share their point of view or opinions. TikTok videos are also a way for content creators to repurpose content from other platforms, such as YouTube videos or Twitch live streams, drawing from them to create highlights or focused material that can be archived and accessed more easily. This study does not claim to be representative of all TikTok content creators, or all cozy game players in general. It does, however, investigate some of the high-profile discussions taking place on the TikTok platform surrounding cozy games, and just what they entail.

Design Principles	Design Elements
Aesthetics	Visually Soft (warm colors, soft shapes)
	Comforting
	Relaxing (soothing, calm audio – ambient and diegetic)
	Familiar
Safety	Low risk situations
	Absence of fight or flight moments / Stress-Free
Abundance	Resources
	Time
Low stakes	Consequences are not detrimental to progress
Connectedness	Social (in/out of game)
	With the gameworld
Growth	Expansion of space,
	Tending to /caring for things (animals, friends, crops, etc.),
Access	Low-barrier to entry regarding player-skill/required knowledge
	Access to space, zones, etc., do not require significant effort
Progression	Player-centric/driven
	Lack of pressure
	Intrinsically Rewarding
Pacing	Deliberate slowness
	Space for reflection / contemplation
	Opportunities for immersion through repetition of tasks

Figure 1. Cozy Game Design Principles and Elements Mapping Chart

To find content, this study searched TikTok for accounts that garnered high view counts (at least in the tens of thousands) for videos that included hashtags such as #cozygames, #cozygaming, and #cozygamer, among others. The search was further narrowed to identify accounts that offered a range of content - not simply previews of forthcoming games in list form (a common finding), but also accounts that offered reviews of cozy games, commentary about cozy games more generally, discussion of the cozy gaming community, and what being a cozy gamer entailed. Due to TikTok’s structure, creators will use as many hashtags as possible to help interested viewers find their content, and it was noted that there was considerable crossover between cozy gaming related hashtags and more general hashtags such as #cozy, #indiegames, #cozygamingsetup, #gamingontiktok, #gamergirl, and #cozyaesthetic, among many others.

Further, many content creators do not limit themselves to one type of content, and as such we

found accounts that mixed cozy games and books, games and the cozy aesthetic generally, cozy games and technology, and several other examples. To help us understand this crossover, we included some high profile accounts in our analysis that had only a few videos centered on cozy games, but that also had many more videos showing off computer rigs and desk setups that embraced a cozy aesthetic (i.e. that featured neutral or soft palettes, subdued lighting, blankets, candles, etc.), as well as one account that included only cozy game reviews but depicted no people nor anything apart from gameplay itself with a voice over. All these choices were made to help us see how content creators are positioning themselves on social media, as well as how cozy games themselves are bleeding into other discussions about gaming rituals, self-care, technology use, and the evolution of who is considered a valid participant in gaming spaces.

Working within these parameters, 11 accounts were identified for analysis, and at least a dozen of the most recent videos from each site were viewed and studied. These accounts had follower counts ranging from 19,400 - >572,000, and the number of likes of their videos ranged from ~500,000 to just under 18 million. Many included the term “cozy” in their account name (cozy.games; cozyteagames; cozyaddy_) to help identify their focus. All the creators studied were women or female-presenting, were young (roughly 20s to late 30s in age), and racially or ethnically diverse. All also regularly updated their accounts with daily or weekly content. Some of the content was clearly taken from other platforms, such as Twitch, but other content appeared specifically created for TikTok. All creators also had linktrees that listed their other social media presence, and nearly universally they had Instagram, Facebook, YouTube, Twitter/X, and (less frequently) Twitch accounts.

Videos were studied for the following elements - how they defined or talked about the definition of cozy games, game reviews that identified the specific elements that they identified as cozy, as well as the composition and content of the videos more generally. That included studying creators’ attire and self-presentation, gaming setups, room/space decorations, use of sound, editing techniques, color schemes, mode of address, as well as any crossover content included.

3. Defining Cozy Games: It’s harder than you think!

The idea and experience of cozy games has been around for quite some time with variations defined as ‘wholesome’ games (Scully-Blaker, 2024) and ‘cute’ games (Guajardo, 2022), which are considered ‘cozy-

adjacent’ in that they adhere to some of the design principles of creating a cozy game, but not completely (Short, et. al., 2018). From life and farm simulators to games that inspire self-reflection, cozy games are often recognized as being wrapped in a soft and comforting aesthetic with low-stakes gameplay that allows players to escape into a time and space free of anxiety and stress. In this way, everyone knows what a cozy game is when they see/play it, but how they are defined depends on who you ask. As we will see throughout this paper, the definition is up for discussion and open to interpretation. While there are a lot of overlapping descriptors and design elements, there is no absolute when it comes to defining (and experiencing) cozy games. Of course, the challenge of defining a game genre is nothing new (Apperley, 2006; Arsenault, 2009), but when a definition is so inherently connected to personal perceptions and a ‘vibe’, the challenge becomes a little more complex.

3.1. Designing & Developing Cozy Games

From a design perspective, codifying a definition of cozy game elements is a relatively young endeavor compared to more established genres such as role-playing games that are based on specific mechanics, narratives, settings, and are grounded in older forms of media. At its core, coziness is meant as a feeling, a vibe of the game play and space. It is most often player-dependent in that how the game is experienced by a player is rooted in their expectations and culture of comfort. It could be argued that this then becomes culturally specific. So, how then, do game designers define the core elements of something that is both universal and personal? By boiling down the concept of cozy to its definitional essence at the level of language, coziness as an adjective is defined as “a feeling of being warm, comfortable, and safe” (Oxford English Dictionary). By working off these three elements alone, it is possible to begin constructing definitional aspects of cozy games within a design frame as the fundamental focus of cozy games is to provide the player with a safe and comfortable environment that elicits feelings of warmth.

Following these three aspects of coziness, there are a handful of guiding principles and practices that have been developed and discussed, most notably by a group of game designers (Jake Forbes, Daniel Cook, Chelsea Howe, Squirrel Eiserloh, Dan Hurd, Anthony Ordon, Joshua Diaz) who came together through Project Horseshoe in 2017 to consider what is meant by ‘cozy’ and to develop some guidelines on how to create cozy games, add coziness to a range of other types of games, and consider design practices and spaces that promote a ‘humanizing design practice in

a society built on monetizing base animal needs” (Short, et. al., 2018). Further design practices have been explored and explained in industry led spaces such as gamesindustry.biz and gamedeveloper.com which are websites devoted to a wide range of game design and development subjects, design instruction and discussion, often with guest authors from the game industry. As formally defining coziness in games and cozy games as a genre is relatively new within the game design field, many of the existing articles and talks used for this paper stem from various members of the group above.

Finally, there is also a growing body of academic research that aims to expand on design literature, analyze existing games, and consider new directions and expectations for the genre. The academic work complements the design literature while providing critical reflection on the genre, its definitional qualities and impact on future game design, players, and experiences (Waszkiewicz and Bakun, 2020; redacted, anon).

The most common feature of cozy games stems from their aesthetics. Cozy games are often soft in color, tone, and textures (Valentine, 2018), offering a pleasing palette for the player meant to be calming and soothing. Though lighter colors have often been correlated to cozy aesthetics, with the shift in themes as noted above, dark tones can also be considered to elicit coziness as long as they are cohesive and warm.

Similarly, audio shapes a game’s overall aesthetic and cozy audio “is continuous, soft, and non-intrusive, with an element of familiarity” (Short et al., 2018, p. 5). They continue to explain that non-diegetic audio be ambient and gentle, whereas diegetic audio should create a sense of intimacy by allowing the player to connect “concretely” with the in-game sources (p.5). This creates a sense of intimacy through connectedness with the game’s environment as well as through a sense of familiarity. In such cases, knowing your audience is important here, as what is familiar is culturally coded.

The second most common element found in the design of cozy games is the aim of creating a sense of safety for the player. This is done in a range of ways, from aesthetics to the mechanics and themes of the game. At the gameplay level, this is created by low-risk tasks and activities with the absence of fight-or-flight moments in the game. This is often done by providing the player with repeated low risk, and arguably, low demand, tasks such as collecting golden feathers in *A Short Hike* (Adamgryu, 2019) or fossils in *Animal Crossing: New Horizons* (Nintendo, 2020). These tasks are often framed as ‘safe rituals’ that do not cause stress or danger (p.15). More specifically, the player should not be put in situations where they

are in danger of failure and any gameplay situation that is presented to the player that has any sort of consequences, should not be done in a confronting manner and not be detrimental to the player’s progress in the game, however that is defined.

Creating opportunities for the player to develop a sense of connectedness is another fundamental design principle that is often associated with cozy gameplay. Social connectedness with in-game characters supports a sense of safety and comfort for the player. Through tasks such as aiding the in-game character to design their homes or run small errands for them like in *Animal Crossing: New Horizons* (Nintendo, 2020), social connections become more familiar as the player learns the tastes and habits of the characters that live on their island. Connectedness can also be with the gameworld itself. Shaping and forming landscapes, building and arranging objects in the game are all ways that allow the player to not only feel connected but also have a sense of agency in the gamespace which has the potential to enhance the player’s comfort within the game. This is connected to the design element of growth. Allowing the players to expand space, garden, tend to the land, take care of crops or flocks of animals through low-risk tasks encourages feelings of belonging and ownership that enhances a sense of security for many players.

Following the idea that cozy games are designed to be ‘stress-free’, it is also important that players are not forced to exert high levels of energy, be it during the gameplay itself, through the physical inputs, or high emotional situations that may cause the player stress or discomfort. Similarly, the representation of actions and tasks should also be stress-free for the game characters, which works to connect the events in the gameworld to the (expected) experience of the player (redacted, anon).

Finally, pacing and progression are two other aspects of cozy game design that counters more common, competitive (be it against the game world and enemies, or other players) game design principles. In cozy games, the pacing is often deliberately slow, giving space for the player to consider, contemplate, and reflect on themes and gameplay rituals in a way that most other games do not.

The rewards of gameplay are most often intrinsic to the player (i.e. gratification at keeping a tidy garden, pride in maintaining social relations with in-game characters, etc.) and are player-driven. While games have tasks and goals, cozy games often leave the progression pace to the player. There is no penalty for not building your town fast enough, vegetables don’t rot if not cultivated in time. With the lack of penalties comes a lack of pressure that allows for gameplay to

follow the pace of and needs of the player, and not the other way around.

While this is not an exhaustive list of design principles and elements, these are some of the core elements of almost all cozy games, whether they are light in narrative or heavy in theme. Through a general analysis of any game that is self-defined as cozy, these elements are most likely to be present.

3.2. Game & Mainstream Media: It's all the things!

Cozy games have garnered a lot of press over the last few years in both games media and the broader mainstream press. From *Polygon* to *The Washington Post*, everyone seems to have something to say about cozy games. Whether it's the reasons people play them (Ehrenkranz, 2023), or how they are defined (Carlos, 2024), chances are these articles get it right some of the time, list games that aren't always considered 'cozy games' some of the time, and inevitably add mud to the definitional waters all the time (Morton, 2024). Regardless, these articles play an important definitional bridge between the creators, the players that they interview, and the public who are probably scratching their heads asking what 'cozy' games are and why they should care.

The most common definitional element of cozy games across all fifteen articles studied here is the notion that they must be 'stress-free'. The idea that videogames are inherently violent or necessarily competitive is one that is consistently debunked (Bellingham, 2022; Gupta, 2023). This correlates to the core design elements of low-stakes/low-risks described in the previous sections. Mainstream media is clear on communicating that these games are not like other video games. Cozy games are "low-stakes, wholesome, and accessible" and can be enjoyed by even the most seasoned gamer when "they are sick of grinding the ranks" (Carlos, 2024). Indeed, they reference the pleasure and comfort that derives from mundane tasks and that 'simplicity is key'. For within this simplicity is how the game provides stress-free gameplay while creating comfort in repetition and ritual.

Arguably, cozy games fulfill a different need than other genres of video games and that's why you, the reader, should pay attention. Cozy games offer players a respite from the hustle and bustle of their everyday lives, of the chaotic world we live in (Carlos, 2024). Unlike many other games that reproduce the challenges and struggles of contemporary or future societies, cozy life simulator games offer the player a satisfying, and stress-free version of everyday life. As Aigner Loren Wilson puts it:

"Imagine it: a life similar to your own, but without the hassle and stakes of the real world. ... Everything has a place, and you are the overseer. It's your world. The purpose of cozy life simulation games, composed of role-playing, management and relaxing gameplay, is to allow the player the space to manage aspects of their characters' lives within a world designed to meet their warmest expectations. In doing so, life simulators "provide players with the perfect escape and replication of life" (Wilson, 2023).



Figure 2. Screenshot of gameplay from *A Witch's Bakery*, cozyteagames' video. Taken by authors, June 14, 2024.

While defining cozy games is not always their focus, what the games and mainstream media do well is argue the case that playing cozy games is worth your time as they outline the many benefits beyond passing time. They have been attributed to helping your mental health (Ehrenkranz, 2023), provide space for comfort and self-reflection (Brinks, 2019) through thoughtful themes and ritual, even some of these themes require more emotional engagement on behalf of the player (Martens, 2021). Because "[C]ozy games don't require prior gaming experience and aren't designed to get your adrenaline running. Quite the opposite — Dunlap says they run on the "tend and befriend" principle. And if you're not challenged to survive, then

you can focus on thriving.” (Kelli Dunlop, psychologist and community director at TakeThis, as quoted in Ehrenkranz, 2023). With this focus on the benefits of playing cozy games, the leading rallying call is that you can, and should, play them, even if you don’t typically consider yourself a ‘gamer’. And for those that do, a reminder that “playing cozy games doesn’t make you less of a gamer” (Leberknight, 2024).

Beyond the reasons to play cozy games, and some core gameplay elements, there is a constant reminder that cozy is a ‘vibe’ (Carlos, 2024; Morton, 2024). It is something you ‘feel’. You know it when you see and play cozy games. It is the sense of calm and relaxation felt when playing a cozy game; the losing sense of time in self-paced gameplay (in what academics would define as flow in games (Chen, 2007)). We see similar reference to ‘vibe’ in the design literature as it is created through carefully crafted aesthetics, color palettes, soothing audio and tasks that are not demanding for the player. With the absence of stressors, all these things allow the player to feel fully immersed in the overall ‘vibe’ of the cozy game world. The challenge with ‘vibe’ and relying on the player to feel it, is that it becomes more of a personal experience. An experience that can be designed only to a certain extent, the rest of it is up to the players.

3.3. It’s all about the vibe: #cozygames and TikTok

If cozy games are the sun, then TikTok is a densely populated satellite moon offering thousands of paratexts that situate and interpret those games. Some of the most popular of those paratexts are provided by accounts such as cozyteagames (with more than 570,000 followers), which publish straightforward reviews of games including the recently released *Tiny Glade*, *Chants of Sennar*, *Tempopo*, and *A Witch’s Bakery*. Minimalist in design, these videos feature gameplay clips, soft background music and voice over narration, without any images of the account’s content creator. Cozyteagames instead focuses on succinct explanations of a game’s activities, challenges, storyline, and characters. For example, in its review of *A Witch’s Bakery*, the gameplay is described as a “magical adventure” which invites players to “wander” and “meander” through Paris, running a bakery and using magic to discover “the emotional wounds of those close to you.” This allows you to then make individualized breads that will heal them. This review also highlights that the game offers players the “homey vibe of a Parisian bakery” (figure 2) and closes by saying the game is best enjoyed with a vanilla rooibos tea: each cozyteagames game review

suggests an accompanying tea that the creator feels best captures the spirit/vibe of the game. As we will argue later, the tea recommendation is more than a random branding element for the channel - making and drinking tea is part of the ritual many cozy gamers engage in, and cozy gaming videos often feature a hot beverage near one’s keyboard or controller. Video content shows a game with pastel colors, cute characters, domestic activities such as rolling out dough, and the Parisian skyline.

Overall, it is apparent that most of the content creators sampled here align with cozy game developers in the elements that they feel make a game cozy. For example, Wendy from hercozygaming writes in a blog post linked to on her TikTok account that “to me cozy means wholesome, light-hearted, carefree, soft and rejuvenating.” Further, horror games “aren’t cozy” because cozy games should “offer comfort for solo gamers.” Yet even hercozygaming will admit that the definition of coziness “is subjective,” with others differing on how they draw their own boundary lines. Livcharetteisagamer takes a more expansive view, believing that “what’s for me may not be for you” and in the end “we’re arguing about videogames - it’s not that serious.”

Videos from creators such as gamergirlgale, livcharetteisagamer, marsyleighs, laelindra, gemzape and others provide game reviews, but also engage in discussions about what specific elements not only make a game cozy, but how their own definition of cozy might differ from others. In a discussion of games in her current play rotation, gemzape reports playing the “cozy mmo” *Palia*, which is cozy to her because it has no combat, and instead features crafting and building with others. She also admits to a choice that might be controversial- the survival horror game *Sons of the Forest*. Gemzape claims even if the storyline is “morbid and horrific,” the graphics are stunning, she plays with friends (which is not explained as mitigating the horror), and the crafting, building, and storyline captured her interest. Similarly, Gamergirlgale argues that for her, cozy games must provide comfort, relaxation, and warmth. Yet even so, in a video about her “favorite unconventional cozy games,” she starts to push the envelope of what is considered cozy, discussing and defending *Fallout*, *Skyrim*, and *Baldur’s Gate 3* as fulfilling those requirements. Coziness is invoked in these games via their open world exploration, the ability of the player to make important choices, and, intriguingly, the aesthetics or “vibe” each game offers. Many of her viewers would seem to agree, with one commenter writing that “Skyrim is the og cosy game.”

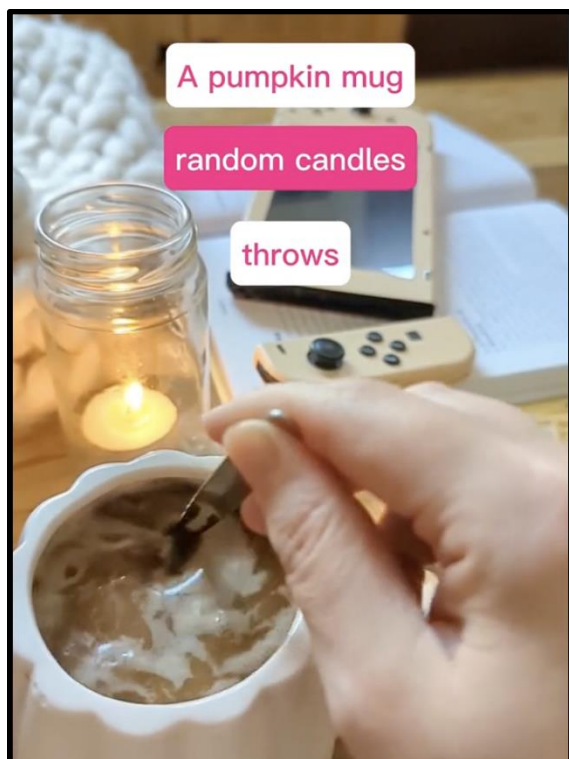


Figure 3: Shot from hercozygaming video showing stereotypical items cozy gamers have in their home. Author screenshot.

Here we can see the challenges involved when no specific mechanic or game element is invoked to describe a game's genre or category. A platformer, for example, involves running and jumping over and past challenging platforms. Yet what is the fundamental "coziness" of a cozy game? That fuzziness is also perhaps why so many content creators and other players fall back on abstract terms to explain their choices - a *vibe*, an *aesthetic* - as a way to position a game within the cozy universe. Sometimes a game's elements check all the cozy boxes, but sometimes (such as in the case of *Baldur's Gate 3* or *Helldivers 2*) it doesn't but has enough cozy *elements* to perpetuate a cozy vibe. As Short et al (2018) explain, cozy elements can be used in games that are not otherwise considered 'cozy' to provide the player space/time to rest, heal, and regroup, or what Waszkiewicz and Bakun (2020) call 'situational' "where coziness is a quality of a singular sequence rather than the entire game." (p. 233).

Another key aspect of content creators' videos is the inclusion of a *cozy context* that surrounds cozy games, cozy gaming, and the cozy gamer. That context appears in many ways, and can differ between creators, but with enough similarities across most to constitute a consistent aesthetic or vibe of coziness itself. Elements of 'coziness' comprise multiple facets,

including room decorations, sound/music being played, mode of address, gaming setup, and the creator's self-presentation.

The use of specific "cozy" room decorations in such videos is so commonplace that hercozygaming created the video "stuff every cozy gamer has in their home that just makes sense" to poke fun at the stereotypical components: fake plants, a pumpkin mug, candles, throws, journals, cute desk setup, a cat under the desk, and so on (figure 3). Indeed, such elements could be found across nearly all cozy gaming videos, apart from those - such as cozyteagames - that did not actually feature anything outside of gameplay or screenshots in their videos.

Desk and room setups also rely on specific color palettes to signal coziness (figure 4). Most images of cozy gamer spaces feature lots of white, cream, beige, taupe, and other neutral tones. It is the unusual video that does not, instead offering bright colors, neon, or a cluttered atmosphere. The content creator themselves, if shown, is usually wearing cozy clothes that could also be considered cozy: sweats, sweaters, big socks, oversized shirts, or a robe. Despite their casual wear, they are also often wearing (or actively applying) makeup, have manicured nails, and modest jewelry. There is soft lighting that enhances their image, but even more importantly, highlights their gaming areas. For example, the account cozyaddy_ mainly presents videos of a highly curated space decorated to signal various "moods," with the creator rarely shown at all. In other videos, content creators such as XiXi_playing appear lounging on a chaise or beanbag, under a blanket, playing games on a Switch or similar console.

Coziness is also signaled through videos of creators actively setting up their gaming stations/comfy chairs as well as engaging in activities such as making coffee or tea, arranging their phone on a standing charger, and doing other tasks in preparation for their next gaming session. These repetitive components often appear regularly, creating a ritual event - where the playing of a cozy game (or a game with enough cozy elements) is only one piece of the larger whole. Likewise, as mentioned earlier, many content creators are not only posting games related content - they also do book reviews, or tech reviews, or discuss other types of games or media. Cozy games become one part of a larger cozy universe, defined loosely enough that most players can find someone to identify with, and some cozy games that fit their own interests and needs.

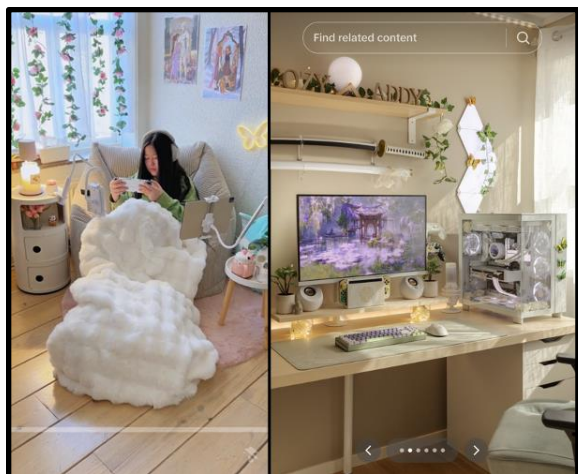


Figure 4. On the left, XiXi playing in her cozy nook. On the right, a gaming setup belonging to cozyaddy_. Screenshots by authors.

4. Conclusion & Future Directions

From soft, comforting aesthetics, and stress-free spaces that allow for moments of reflection or a respite from the action to an abundance of resources and low-risk gameplay, many of the design elements that define ‘cozy’ games exist in almost all video games to some extent. Yet not all games are considered ‘cozy’ at a purely definitional level. Even games that are given the label of cozy by designers, critics, and players such as *Spiritfarer* (Thunder Lotus Games, 2021) are often challenged for addressing themes that are not typically considered ‘cozy’ such as ‘death, dying, and grief’ (de Pan and Bosman, 2024).

And yet, as the genre increases in popularity, we are no closer to agreeing upon and pinning down the generic elements before the rise of hybrid genres begins to appear. As the audience for cozy games continues to grow, so does the need for new and unique gameplay experiences. To this end, we are seeing the inclusion of games that have light combat, offer visual elements not typically considered ‘cozy’ such as gothic creepiness and darker themes as noted above. These elements work to “partially reject[s] the expectation of ludic safety”, an often-considered core component of cozy games, in what Waszkiewicz proposes the term ‘dark cozy games’ (2024). The question then begs, if cozy games continue to expand into aesthetics, gameplay, and themes that are not, at their core, typically considered to afford a sense of comfort, safety and warmth, are they even cozy games at all?

While players have a wide range of opinions of what constitutes a cozy game, they can only do so based on what is currently available to them (unless, of course, they delve into game design themselves,

which could be an interesting future research direction). So how does the ever-shifting framing of cozy games get defined and discussed by the players? How do they define the ‘vibe’ if the landscape of cozy games continues to be fluid and situational?

As we have seen throughout this paper, while there are core elements that could be implemented to meet the fundamental characteristics of what makes a game cozy, there is no consensus between game designers, academics, game and mainstream press, and most importantly, the player and fanbase of what constitutes a fully defined, pure ‘cozy game’. Without such an agreement, and we agree that the experience of cozy games is grounded in the player’s experience (Short et al, 2018), then cozy games, by their very nature, are necessarily fluid in structure, aesthetics, themes and settings. This ultimately fits with the larger notion that “[g]enre serves as keys to understanding how to participate in the actions of a community” (Miller, 1984, p.165), and that cozy games, as a genre, are a constantly negotiated space between players, games and their creators, and the media surrounding and commenting on these interactions. Yet ultimately it is through the individual perceptions of safety and comfort that the world of cozy games opens to witchy vibes and haunting worlds that continue to have the potential to encompass their players in many different cozy wrappers.

From this position, there are several future directions this research can take. Evidenced through the content creator’s videos, there is currently a very gendered aesthetic and audience of cozy games, but as their themes and aesthetics continue to develop, what does that growing audience look like? Another research direction that has bubbled to the surface throughout the research for this article, mainly in the game and mainstream press, is how cozy games managed to carve a reputation as being within the realm of ‘real’ games, unlike ‘casual’ and mobile games. Where does this legitimacy come from? Is it rooted in its game design, or more socially constructed within its fan base and communities? Finally, as demonstrated in the TikTok videos, the concept and ritual of cozy goes well beyond the confines of the screen. With the inclusion of ‘dark cozy games’, and whatever may come next, how are these setups, spaces, and rituals created and maintained and how do they influence the cozy vibe of games?

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